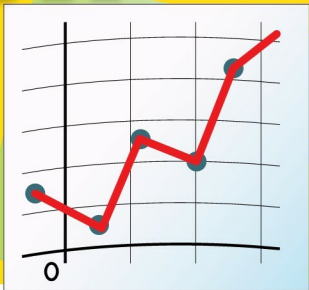


Graph Your Network!



Graphs always make work easier, especially when we need to monitor things. In this article, we'll discuss Cacti, a simple graphical network monitor.

At some time or the other, many of us have felt the need to monitor different statistics regarding the machine connected to our network. SNMP (Simple Network Management Protocol) provides a standard set of network management tools to do so. Another useful tool is RRDTool, which is supposed to be an open source industry standard – a high-performance data logging and graphing system for time series data. Both these tools are really powerful and provide a base for many projects. One such project we will take a look at in this article is Cacti.

What is Cacti?

Cacti, according to the project website, is "a complete network graphing solution designed to harness the power of RRDTool's

data storage and graphing functionality. Cacti provides a fast poller, advanced graph templating, multiple data acquisition methods, and user management features out-of-the-box. All of this is wrapped in an intuitive, easy to use interface that makes sense for LAN-sized installations up to complex networks with hundreds of devices." Figure 1 shows a preview of Cacti graphs.

With a PHP-driven front-end, Cacti has the ability to store the required information to create the graphs and populate them with data in a MySQL database. Apart from the ability to maintain graphs, data sources, and round-robin archives in a database, Cacti can even handle data gathering. As for those who want to create traffic graphs with MRTG (Multi Router Traffic Grapher), there is the obvious SNMP support. For a complete list of important features, take a look at the box.